System Architecture — Blueprint v3

PQC Security Framework for In-Vehicle CAN-FD Networks

(Extension of Castiglione & Elia, 2025)

Logical Pure-Star Security Architecture
over Physically Segmented CAN-FD Domains

Version 3.0 — August 2026

Phase 1–2 Scope Only

0. Framing & Scope

This section describes the Phase 1–2 architecture exclusively (V2X, OTA, and physical HIL deployment are out of scope here and belong to Phases 3–4 per the workload plan).

The architecture inherits the segmented CAN-FD network model from Castiglione & Elia but fundamentally replaces three of its core baseline assumptions:

- Pre-shared static seed → Replaced by PUF-derived hardware-rooted enrollment.
- Semi-trusted local gateways → Replaced by a single fully-trusted Central Intelligent Security Gateway (CISG).
- No attestation → Replaced by ML-DSA-44 post-quantum attestation over an indexed block transfer protocol.

The trust boundaries visualised and enforced in this architecture strictly follow the authoritative Trust Boundary Analysis (Table 3), establishing the CISG as the absolute root of trust.

1. Component Inventory

The ECU performs Ascon-AEAD128 encryption before transmitting. The CISG is the cryptographic termination point for inter-domain traffic and a passive monitor for intra-domain traffic. The CISG is the sole point in the architecture where decrypted plaintext from other ECUs exists.

Component	Owner	Trust Status	Role
ECU (Generic Node)	N/A	Untrusted (pre-auth) → Authenticated, continuously monitored (post-attestation)	Generates telemetry; encrypts/decrypts traffic using session keys. An authenticated ECU can subsequently become compromised while retaining valid credentials — hence IDS monitoring.
SRAM-PUF + Fuzzy Extractor	Kunal	Trusted (Hardware Root)	Lives inside each ECU. Reconstructs hardware-intrinsic secret for identity.
Central Gateway (CISG)	N/A	Fully Trusted (Always)	Sole routing hub and security authority. Decrypts inbound AEAD traffic, inspects plaintext, and re-encrypts for inter-domain forwarding. Passively monitors intra-domain traffic for IDS.
Session Provisioning	Kunal	Trusted	Handles HKDF derivation of the per-boot K_boot_i and Ascon-AEAD128-protected delivery of the fresh random K_i from CISG to ECU.
ML-DSA Attestation	Kaustuv	Trusted	Generates and verifies post-quantum digital signatures (ML-DSA-44 / FIPS 204).
Block-Transfer Engine	Kaustuv	Trusted	Fragments 2436B attestation object into 41-frame burst with NACK recovery.
Secure Data Frame	Tapan	Trusted	Constructs/parses 64-byte runtime frames, extracts metadata, manages 32-bit monotonic freshness counter.
LSTM-Autoencoder IDS	Tapan	Trusted	Gateway-hosted anomaly detection. Inspects 12D feature vector post-decryption.
Federated Learning	Tapan	Trusted	Cross-vehicle model updates (Flower/FedAvg). Raw telemetry never leaves the vehicle.

2. Domain Segmentation Model

Logical Pure-Star Security Architecture over Physically Segmented CAN-FD Domains

The vehicle is divided into four distinct electrical CAN-FD domains (Powertrain, Chassis, Body & Comfort, Infotainment). Each domain is an electrically independent CAN-FD broadcast bus. The CISG connects to each domain through a dedicated CAN-FD controller/transceiver interface.

IMPORTANT: Physical vs. Logical Security Topology: The proposed architecture uses a physically segmented CAN-FD topology rather than a literal ECU-to-Gateway physical star. Each functional domain consists of a shared CAN-FD bus containing its assigned ECUs, with the CISG connected to each domain through a dedicated CAN-FD interface.

The "Logical Pure Star" designation refers to the cryptographic and security architecture: each ECU possesses a unique session key K_i, and the CISG is the central trusted authority for authentication, inter-domain routing, cryptographic verification, IDS inspection, and session-key provisioning. ECUs do not share cryptographic keys.

Because CAN-FD is broadcast within a physical domain, an ECU may physically observe frames transmitted by other ECUs on the same bus. However, it cannot decrypt frames protected under another ECU's K_i. The CISG cannot physically prevent same-domain frame transmission; its active enforcement authority applies to inter-domain forwarding and security processing.

Gateway Operating Modes (From Physical Architecture v1.1)

Mode	Scope	CISG Behaviour
Passive Monitoring (Intra-domain)	ECUs on the same CAN-FD bus	CISG observes traffic through its attached interface for IDS analysis but CANNOT physically block the first transmitted frame. ECUs communicate directly over the shared bus.
Active Gatekeeper (Inter-domain)	Traffic between different CAN-FD domains	All traffic passes through the CISG. The gateway performs routing, policy enforcement, decryption, IDS inspection, re-encryption, and may permit or deny forwarding.

Key Scope & Membership

- Key Contexts (One per ECU): The CISG maintains exactly one active session key (K_i) per authenticated ECU. The gateway's metadata bookkeeping consists of a simple N-entry routing table mapping SENDER_ECU_ID → K_i.
- Domain-Group Membership: The assignment of an ECU to a specific domain is static and defined at enrollment time. The DOMAIN_ID is included in the CAN-FD frame header as routing and IDS metadata, but it is NOT used to select cryptographic keys.
- Trade-off Explicitly Acknowledged: Because keys are scoped per ECU rather than per domain, ECUs sharing a physical CAN-FD domain may observe each other's frames at the bus level but cannot decrypt frames protected under another ECU's K_i. For authorized inter-domain communication, the CISG decrypts and validates the source frame, applies gateway/IDS policy, and re-encrypts the message under the authorized destination ECU's K_j before forwarding it to the destination domain. Same-domain transmission remains physically broadcast and is therefore monitored rather than physically intercepted by the CISG.

Physical Domain → Policy Class Mapping

The Trust Boundary Analysis defines the Default-Deny routing policy using three policy class names (Safety, Comfort, Infotainment). The physical architecture uses four domain names. The mapping between them is:

Physical CAN-FD Domain	Policy Class	Rationale
Powertrain	Safety	Engine/Transmission ECUs are safety-critical; same protection tier as Chassis
Chassis	Safety	ABS/EPS ECUs directly affect vehicle dynamics; highest protection class
Body & Comfort	Comfort	BCM/HVAC are convenience functions; no direct safety path
Infotainment	Infotainment	Head Unit/Telematics; highest external exposure, no safety authority

Default-Deny Inter-Domain Routing Policy

The CISG enforces a Default-Deny policy for all inter-domain traffic. Frames that do not match an explicit Allow rule are dropped silently. All forwarding decisions are made after the full gateway acceptance pipeline (format check → session check → counter check → AEAD tag verification).

Source Policy Class	Destination Policy Class	Forwarding Decision	Notes
Safety	Infotainment	ALLOW (read-only telemetry)	Speed, RPM etc. to Head Unit is permitted
Safety	Comfort	BLOCK	No safety signal exposed to Comfort domain
Comfort	Safety	BLOCK	Comfort ECUs have no authority over safety systems
Infotainment	Comfort	ALLOW (selected IDs only)	Restricted whitelist of CAN identifiers
Infotainment	Safety	STRICTLY BLOCK	Highest-priority rule; enforced unconditionally
Any	Any (same domain)	Intra-domain — not intercepted	CISG passively monitors; cannot block same-bus traffic

IMPORTANT: Automatic enforcement of this matrix requires CISG firmware to correctly map SENDER_ECU_ID → physical domain → policy class at runtime. Any misconfiguration of this mapping is a security-critical failure mode.

3. End-to-End Data Flow

This section details the complete lifecycle of a secure telemetry transaction, from initial hardware root-of-trust enrollment to runtime anomaly detection at the gateway.

NOTE: Key Scope: The session key delivery and re-encryption steps operate on per-ECU keys (K_i, K_j), adhering strictly to the v1.6 Logical Pure Star topology.

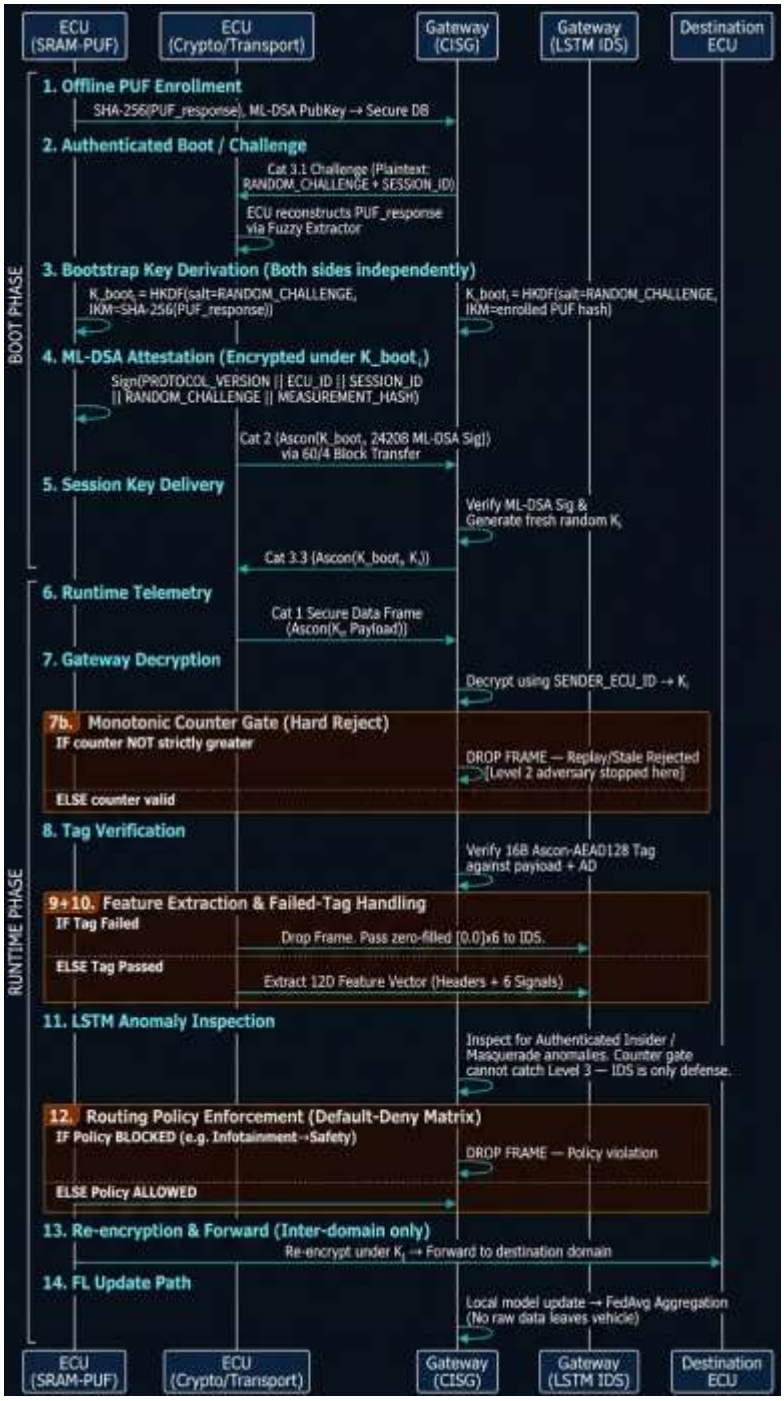


Figure 1: End-to-End Data Flow — 14-Stage Secure Telemetry Lifecycle (incl. Step 7b Counter Gate & Step 12 Routing Policy Enforcement)

1. PUF Enrollment: During manufacturing or secure initialization, the ECU reconstructs its device-root secret via the fuzzy extractor. The Gateway (CISG) stores only the derived verification material (the SHA-256(PUF_response) and the ML-DSA public key) in its secure enrollment database. It never stores the raw hardware secret.

2. Authenticated Boot / Challenge-Response: At startup, the Gateway issues a plaintext Category 3.1 challenge containing a fresh SESSION_ID and a 16-byte cryptographically secure RANDOM_CHALLENGE.

3. Bootstrap Key Derivation: Both the ECU and CISG independently derive the per-boot K_boot_i using HKDF-Extract(salt = RANDOM_CHALLENGE, IKM = SHA-256(PUF_response)), followed by HKDF-Expand(PRK_boot, info = "CAPSTONE-V1/BOOTSTRAP-KEY" || TARGET_ECU_ID || SESSION_ID, L = 16 bytes). The raw PUF response never leaves the ECU.

4. ML-DSA Attestation: The ECU signs an attestation transcript containing PROTOCOL_VERSION || ECU_ID || SESSION_ID || RANDOM_CHALLENGE || MEASUREMENT_HASH, binding the attestation to the ECU identity, current boot session, freshness challenge, and measured software/configuration state. The 2420B signature is protected in one Ascon-AEAD128 operation using K_boot_i (with RANDOM_CHALLENGE as the nonce), producing the 2436B attestation object. It is transferred using the 60/4 indexed block-transfer protocol (a 41-frame burst with NACK recovery).

5. Session Key Delivery: After verifying the ML-DSA signature against the enrolled public key, the CISG generates a fresh, random 128-bit operational session key (K_i) for that specific ECU, and delivers it wrapped in Ascon-AEAD128 under K_boot_i via a Category 3.3 frame.

6. Runtime Telemetry (Secure Data Frame): The ECU transmits normal runtime traffic in 64-byte CAN-FD Category 1 frames. The Ascon nonce is constructed locally (never sent on the wire). A 32-bit freshness counter is sent in plaintext AD. The frame yields a 40-byte ciphertext payload and a full 16-byte Ascon-AEAD128 authentication tag.

7. Gateway Decryption: The CISG receives the frame, uses SENDER_ECU_ID to look up K_i, and attempts decryption.

7b. Monotonic Counter Gate (Hard Reject): Before any IDS processing, the CISG checks the MONOTONIC_COUNTER in the Associated Data against the last accepted counter value for this SENDER_ECU_ID. The frame is REJECTED OUTRIGHT if the counter is not strictly greater than the last accepted value. This is a hard enforcement gate — a replayed or stale frame that nevertheless carries a valid Ascon-AEAD128 tag is still dropped here. This step is architecturally distinct from the LSTM's Counter_Gap feature (which detects unusual gaps, not non-monotonicity). Security posture: replay attacks by an active adversary (Level 2) are rejected at the counter gate before ever reaching the IDS. The masquerade threat (Level 3) is an authenticated ECU sending fresh, monotonically valid but behaviourally anomalous frames — the counter gate cannot detect this, which is precisely why the LSTM IDS exists.

8. Tag Verification: The CISG verifies the 16-byte authentication tag against the decrypted payload and Associated Data (AD). Because the MONOTONIC_COUNTER is part of the AD, any tampered or replayed

frame (where the counter was altered after encryption) will also fail tag verification. The counter gate (Step 7b) catches replay of a fully intact original frame before this point.

9. IDS Feature Extraction: The CISG parses the plaintext header and decrypted payload into a 12-dimensional feature vector:

- Header metadata: Δt inter-arrival, Counter_Gap, SENDER_ECU_ID, DOMAIN_ID, Msg_Type
- Crypto metadata: Tag_Verification_Status
- Telemetry signals: 6 plaintext signals (Vehicle Speed, Engine RPM, etc.)

10. Failed-Tag Handling: If tag verification fails, the CISG drops the frame, blocks forwarding, and zeroes out the 6 payload signal features ([0.0]×6). This ensures corrupted ciphertext cannot pollute the LSTM's sequence state, while leaving a distinct anomaly footprint for the model (failed tag + counter gap).

11. LSTM Anomaly Inspection: The 12D feature vector is fed to the gateway-hosted ONNX LSTM Autoencoder. This layer specifically catches the 'Authenticated Insider / Masquerade' threat — where a compromised ECU sends cryptographically valid, monotonically fresh frames that are behaviourally anomalous. The counter gate and AEAD tag cannot detect this threat; the IDS is the only defense.

12. Routing Policy Enforcement: Before forwarding, the CISG maps the source ECU's physical domain to its policy class and applies the Default-Deny routing matrix (Section 2). Frames that violate the policy (e.g. Infotainment → Safety) are dropped regardless of cryptographic validity or IDS score.

13. Re-encryption & Forward (Inter-domain): For frames that pass all prior gates, the CISG re-encrypts the 40-byte payload with a fresh nonce under the destination ECU's session key (K_j) and injects the new frame onto the destination domain's CAN-FD bus. For intra-domain traffic, the CISG passively monitors and logs but does not re-encrypt or re-transmit.

14. FL Update Path: The local LSTM model trains on the gateway. Local model weights (not raw telemetry) are aggregated via Federated Learning (Flower/FedAvg) across simulated vehicles. Raw telemetry data never leaves the vehicle.

4. Trust Boundary Overlay

The Gateway as a Decryption Point (Not Just Routing)

It is critical to explicitly state that the CISG is a decryption point, not merely a blind routing node. At runtime, the Gateway holds plaintext telemetry signals and per-ECU session keys (K_i) in its memory. This is a significantly stronger trust assumption than a blind relay. It is precisely why the Gateway is treated as the sole fully-trusted node rather than one of several semi-trusted local gateways. A full compromise of the CISG compromises the confidentiality of the entire vehicle network.

Baseline vs. Novel Trust Model (Table 3)

Component / Layer	Castiglione & Elia (2025) Baseline	Proposed Phase 1-2 Architecture
Physical Topology	Segmented CAN with multiple local gateways	Segmented CAN-FD with single central CISG
Identity Root	Pre-shared static seed (susceptible to physical extraction)	SRAM-PUF hardware-intrinsic secret
Gateway Trust	Multiple semi-trusted local gateways	Single fully-trusted Central Intelligent Security Gateway (CISG)
Attestation	None	ML-DSA-44 post-quantum attestation over indexed block transfer
Intra-Domain Enforcement	N/A	Passive monitoring only (CISG cannot block same-bus traffic)
Inter-Domain Enforcement	Gateway routing	Active decryption, IDS inspection, re-encryption, policy enforcement
Intrusion Detection	Decentralised	Centralised Gateway-hosted ONNX LSTM Autoencoder
ECU Trust After Auth	Implicitly trusted	Authenticated but continuously monitored

Out of Scope Explicit Annotations

To ensure this architecture does not imply protections it does not provide, the following are explicitly out of scope for Phases 1–2:

- Automatic Gateway Isolation: The IDS detects anomalies but does not physically partition or isolate ECUs in this phase.
- Intra-Domain Physical Interception: The CISG cannot prevent ECUs on the same physical CAN-FD bus from transmitting to each other. Per-ECU keys prevent decryption but not physical bus observation.
- V2X (Vehicle-to-Everything) Security: Outbound external communication is not covered.
- OTA (Over-the-Air) Updates: Firmware update security is out of scope.

5. Interface Contracts

This section defines the precise handoffs between the modular components owned by the team (Cryptography, Transport, and Data/ML).

Attestation → Session Provisioning (Kunal)

Contract: The session provisioning HKDF consumes exactly two elements from the attestation boot phase to derive K_boot_i:

- IKM (Input Keying Material): SHA-256(PUF_response)

- Salt: RANDOM_CHALLENGE (16 bytes, received from the CISG in Cat 3.1)
- Note: The SESSION_ID and TARGET_ECU_ID are only used as contextual info in the HKDF-Expand step.

Session Provisioning → Secure Data Frame (Tapan)

Contract: The CISG generates a fresh operational session key (K_i) and delivers it to the ECU. In the runtime Secure Data Frame (Category 1), the cryptographic context is resolved exclusively via the SENDER_ECU_ID (Byte 1) in the Associated Data (AD). The DOMAIN_ID is present for IDS routing metadata only, not for key selection.

Block-Transfer → Attestation (Kaustuv & Kunal)

Contract: The ML-DSA-44 signature (2420B) is encrypted in a single Ascon-AEAD128 operation to produce a 2436B protected object (2420B ciphertext + 16B tag). Kaustuv's 60/4 block-transfer protocol imposes a strict 60-byte payload limit per frame. Therefore, the 2436B object is fragmented into exactly 41 frames (40 full frames of 60B + 1 frame with 36 bytes data + 24 bytes zero-padding). Category 3.2 selective NACK frames use compact 16-byte payloads (CAN-FD DLC 10).

Secure Data Frame → IDS (Tapan)

Contract: The CISG extracts a 12-dimensional feature vector for the LSTM:

- 5 Metadata Fields: Δt, Counter_Gap, SENDER_ECU_ID, DOMAIN_ID, Msg_Type
- 1 Crypto Field: Tag_Verification_Status (0.0 = Valid Tag, 1.0 = Tag Failure / Corruption)
- 6 Telemetry Fields: Vehicle Speed (f_7), Engine RPM (f_8), Steering Angle (f_9), Brake Pressure (f_10), Longitudinal Accel (f_11), DTC Error Count (f_12)
- Critical Zero-Fill Behavior: If the Ascon-AEAD128 tag fails (Tag_Verification_Status = 1.0), the 6 telemetry signals are forcefully zero-filled to [0.0]×6 before passing the vector to the IDS. This guarantees that corrupted or malicious ciphertext cannot pollute the LSTM's internal sequence state.

6. Residual Threats

While the combination of ML-DSA attestation and Ascon-AEAD128 encryption severely hardens the vehicle network, this architecture does not claim to definitively "solve" all threats outlined in the base paper. Specifically, replay attacks (within the monotonic counter window), Denial of Service (DoS/flooding), and Black/Gray-Hole routing attacks remain residual risks. Network segmentation and encryption reduce the exposure surface, but the LSTM IDS and Federated Learning layer serve as the actual mitigation attempt for these threats. Even then, the IDS is currently scoped strictly to detection, not prevention, acknowledging the limitations of Phase 1–2 development.

NOTE: Black-Hole / Gray-Hole Note: These are not active threats during Phases 1–2 because the architecture contains a single trusted Central Gateway and no intermediate forwarding routers. They become relevant only if intermediate routers are introduced or the Gateway trust assumption is relaxed.

Document Changelog

Version	Date	Changes
v1	Aug 2026	Initial draft (Sections 0–2).
v2	Aug 2026	Added Sections 3–6 and generated Word document.
v3	Aug 2026	Major corrections: (1) Replaced "Pure Star Topology" with "Logical Pure-Star Security Architecture over Physically Segmented CAN-FD Domains" — physically honest about shared CAN-FD buses. (2) Fixed K_boot derivation order (now Step 3, before attestation Step 4). (3) Changed ECU trust status from "Trusted" to "Authenticated, continuously monitored". (4) Fixed Session Provisioning description to distinguish HKDF-derived K_boot from fresh random K_i. (5) Added explicit ML-DSA attestation transcript fields (PROTOCOL_VERSION || ECU_ID || SESSION_ID || RANDOM_CHALLENGE || MEASUREMENT_HASH). (6) Added Gateway Operating Modes table (Passive Monitoring vs Active Gatekeeper). (7) Corrected same-domain broadcast language to be physically honest. (8) Added Intra-Domain Physical Interception to Out of Scope annotations. (9) Re-verified against Physical Architecture v1.1, Trust Boundary Analysis, Literature Survey, and all project context files.